NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Study

Organise a course and turn your own materials into grounded practice.

The Study vault keeps subjects, schedules, notes, imported materials, recordings, concepts, questions and spaced review within one private learning workspace.

VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	University and lifelong learners managing substantial course material.

Contents

Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

Start here if Nodus is new to you. These chapters explain what a vault is, how to move through the application, how sources remain traceable, when a model is optional and how to keep a recoverable copy of the work.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

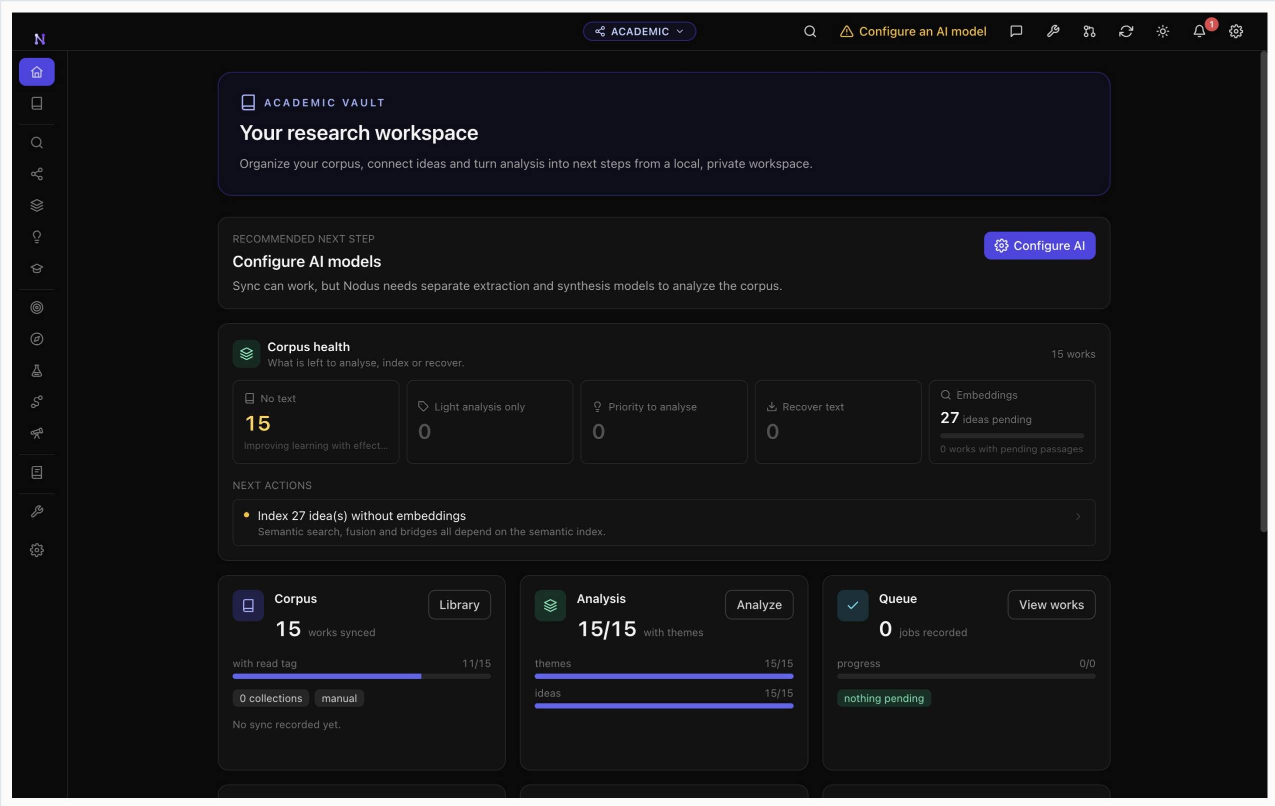
WHERE TO FIND IT Install Nodus, then open the application

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

A vault is an independent workspace for one project, course, family or dataset. Changing the vault changes the navigation and assistant context, while the database, indexes and preserved files stay on the computer. Accounts are optional, and model-assisted features run only after a provider or local model has been configured.

1. Download the package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page and complete the installer.
2. Launch Nodus and complete the short setup: appearance, optional Nodi assistant and the introductory tour.
3. Create the vault that matches the work you are starting, give it a clear name and remain on Home while you learn the layout.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
>
> Start with a small set of real material that you are allowed to process.



Welcome to Nodus in the Nodus desktop application

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

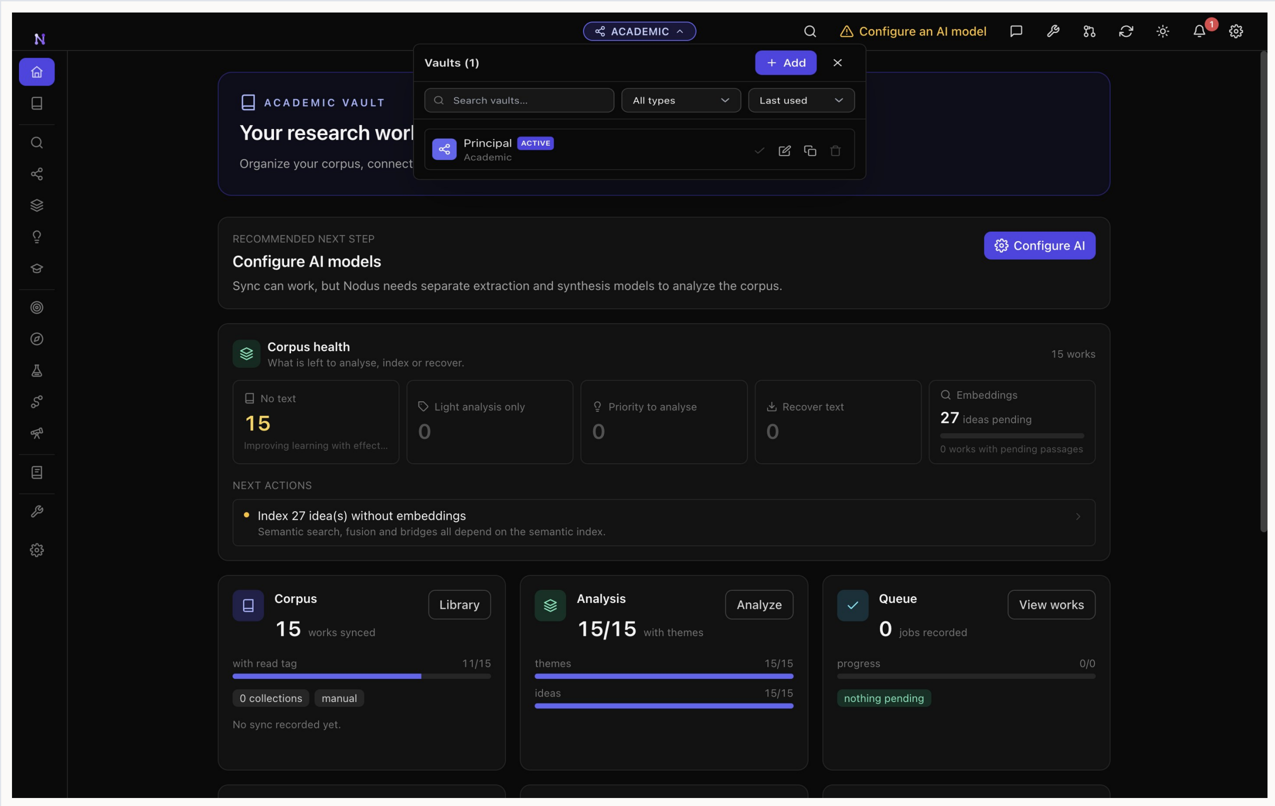
WHERE TO FIND IT Application header → vault name and icon

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

1. Select the current vault name in the centre of the application header, then choose the action to create a vault.
2. Enter a descriptive name, select the correct vault type and read the explanation of the workflow it enables before confirming.
3. Open the same switcher whenever you need another project; choose a vault and wait for its Home view to appear.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Use explicit names such as ‘MA thesis - memory’ or ‘Biology 2026’.
>
> Create a new vault instead of changing the meaning of a mature workspace.



Create and switch vaults in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

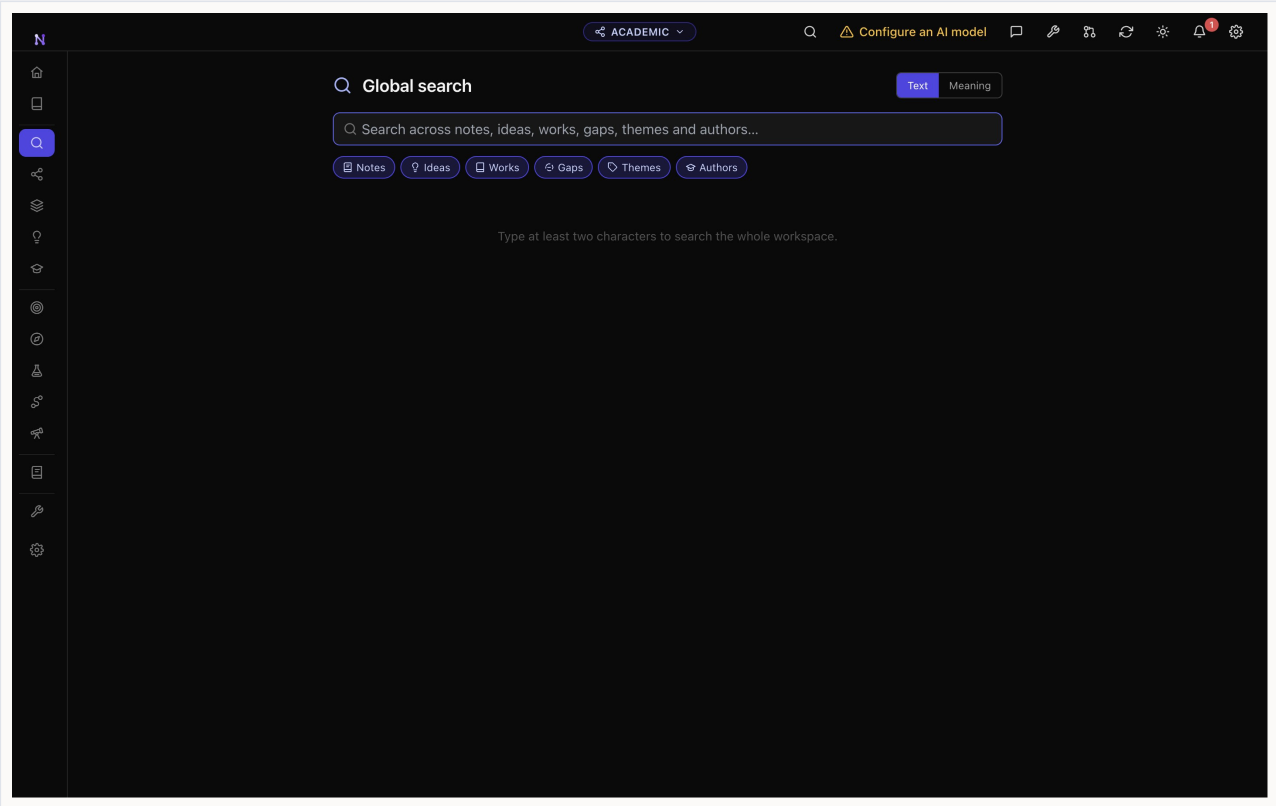
WHERE TO FIND IT Left sidebar → magnifying-glass icon

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

The narrow left sidebar contains the active vault's tools. Hover an icon to read its label. The magnifying-glass button opens search, while the vault button in the header changes workspace. Keyword search works immediately; semantic retrieval also requires an embedding model.

1. Move the pointer over sidebar icons until the label for the section you need appears, then select it; the active icon receives the vault colour.
2. Open Search and enter a title, name, quotation or concept of at least two meaningful characters.
3. Apply a type or scope filter when available, open a result and follow its source link to the original document, record, person or note.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Search for concepts as well as exact titles.
>
> Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.



Navigation and global search in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

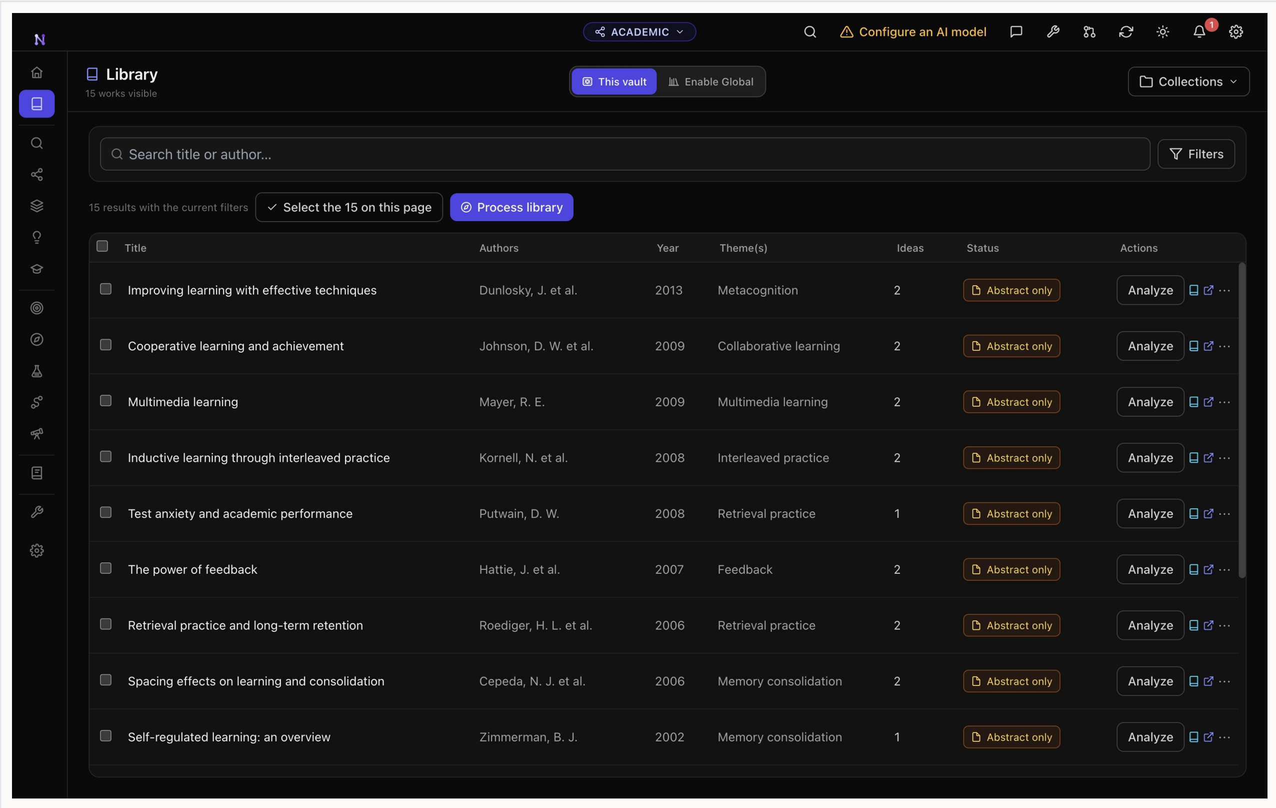
WHERE TO FIND IT Nodus > Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.
3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
>
> Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



Library, sources and reader in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

WHERE TO FIND IT Left sidebar → Settings → AI and providers

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Nodus can be used without a model for deterministic organisation and editing. Features that generate, explain or synthesise text need a configured provider or compatible local endpoint. Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain, and task models let extraction, chat and reports use different choices.

1. Open Settings and find the AI provider section. Choose a cloud provider or enter the address of a compatible local endpoint.
2. Enter the required credential, use the connection test and resolve any error before continuing.
3. Assign a model to each available task, save the settings and test it on a small, non-sensitive source.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
>
> Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

WHERE TO FIND IT Nodus > Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
>
> Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

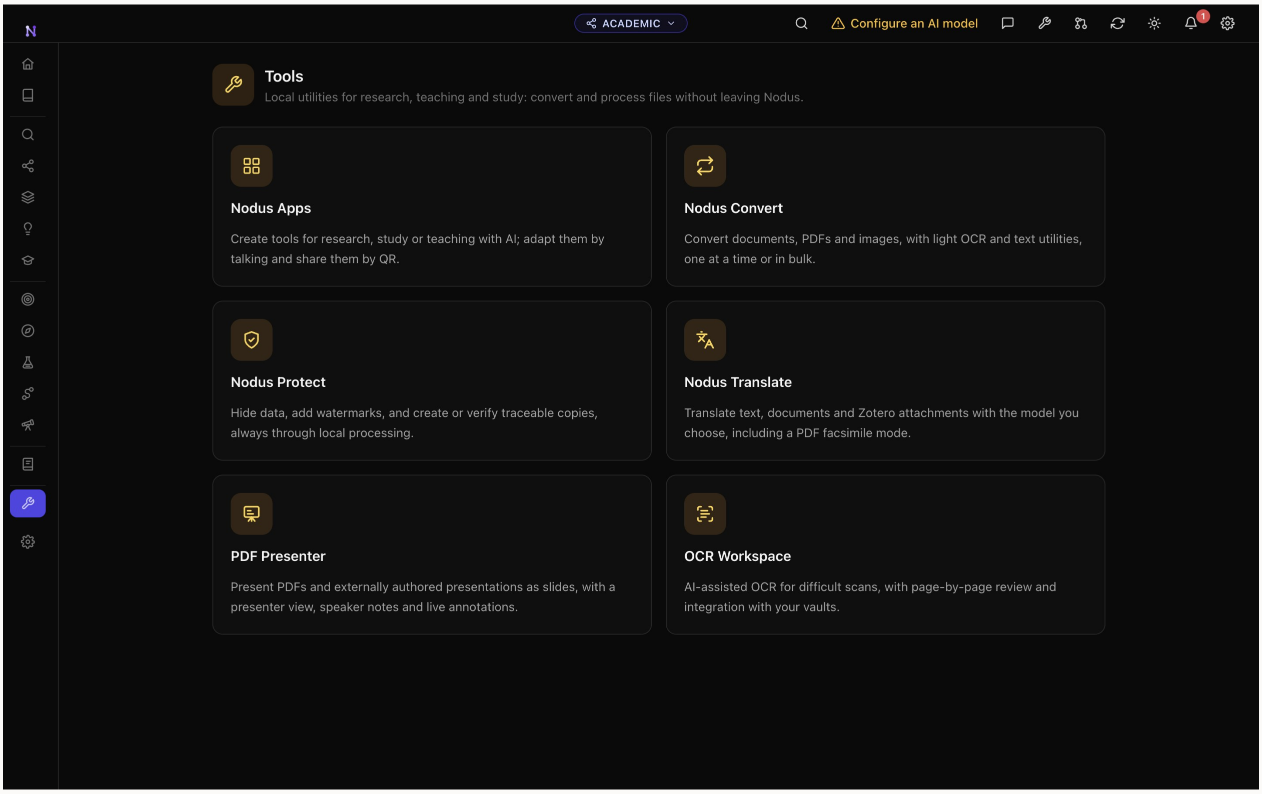
WHERE TO FIND IT Left sidebar → wrench icon → Toolkit

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit contains file utilities shared by every vault. Integrations are optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word can use selected Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source, then review every output option and destination.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with a non-sensitive file before using project material.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
>
> Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

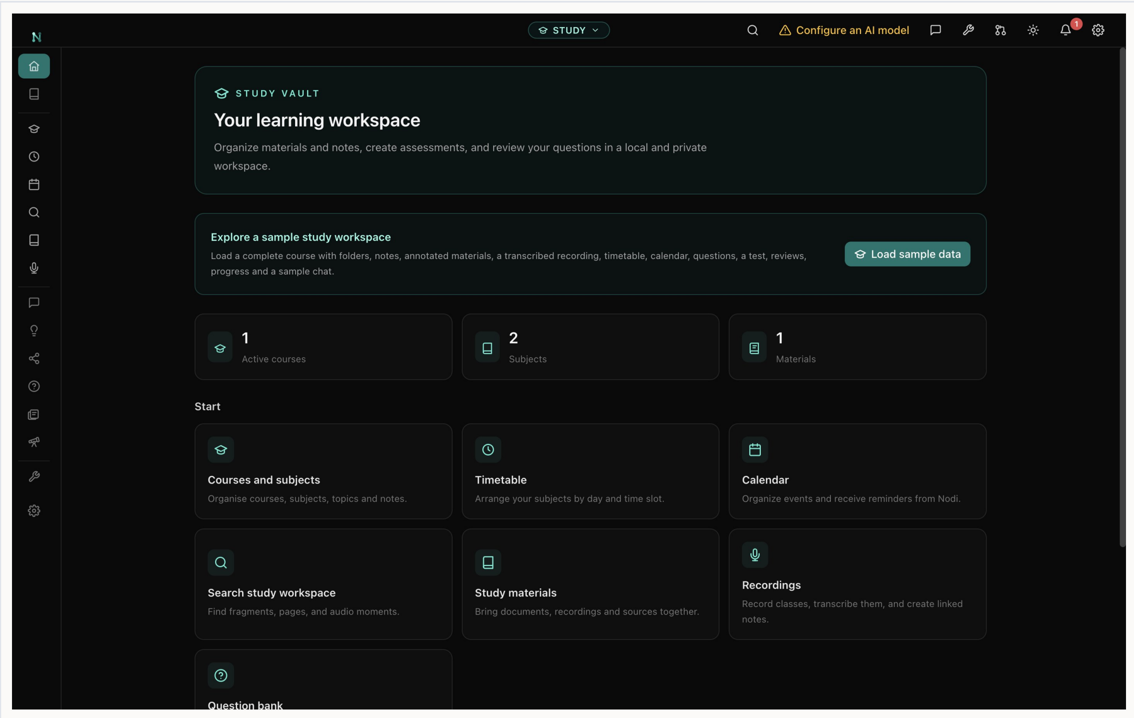


Toolkit and integrations in the Nodus desktop application

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Study workflow

The Study vault keeps subjects, schedules, notes, imported materials, recordings, concepts, questions and spaced review within one private learning workspace.



Study vault home in the Nodus desktop application

ORIENTATION

1 Home and study plan

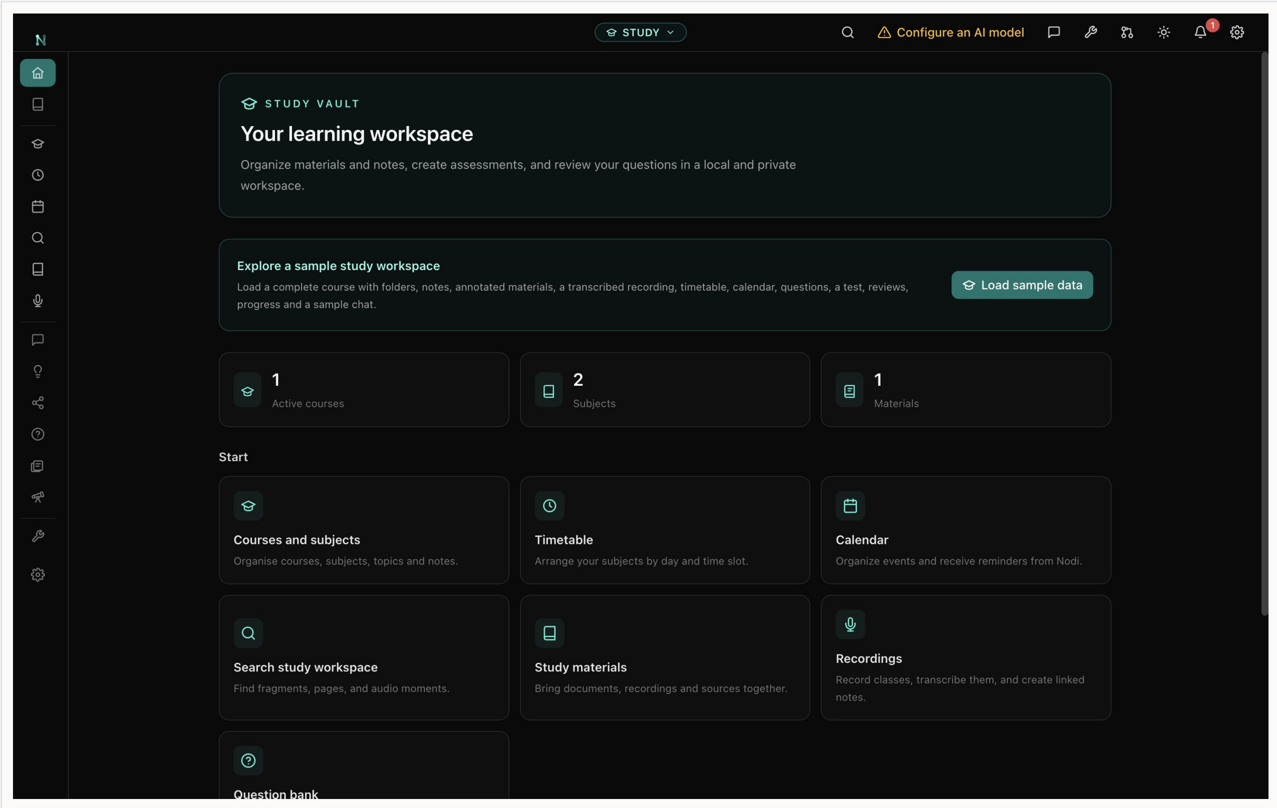
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Home and study plan

See courses, materials, upcoming exams, review load and recommended next steps.

Home consolidates organisation and learning progress without replacing the detailed subject or review views.

1. Check upcoming assessments and scheduled study sessions.
2. Review new material and due review counts.
3. Open the recommended action or a recent note to continue.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Plan from deadlines backwards and keep review sessions small and frequent.



Home and study plan in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

2 Courses, subjects, folders and topics

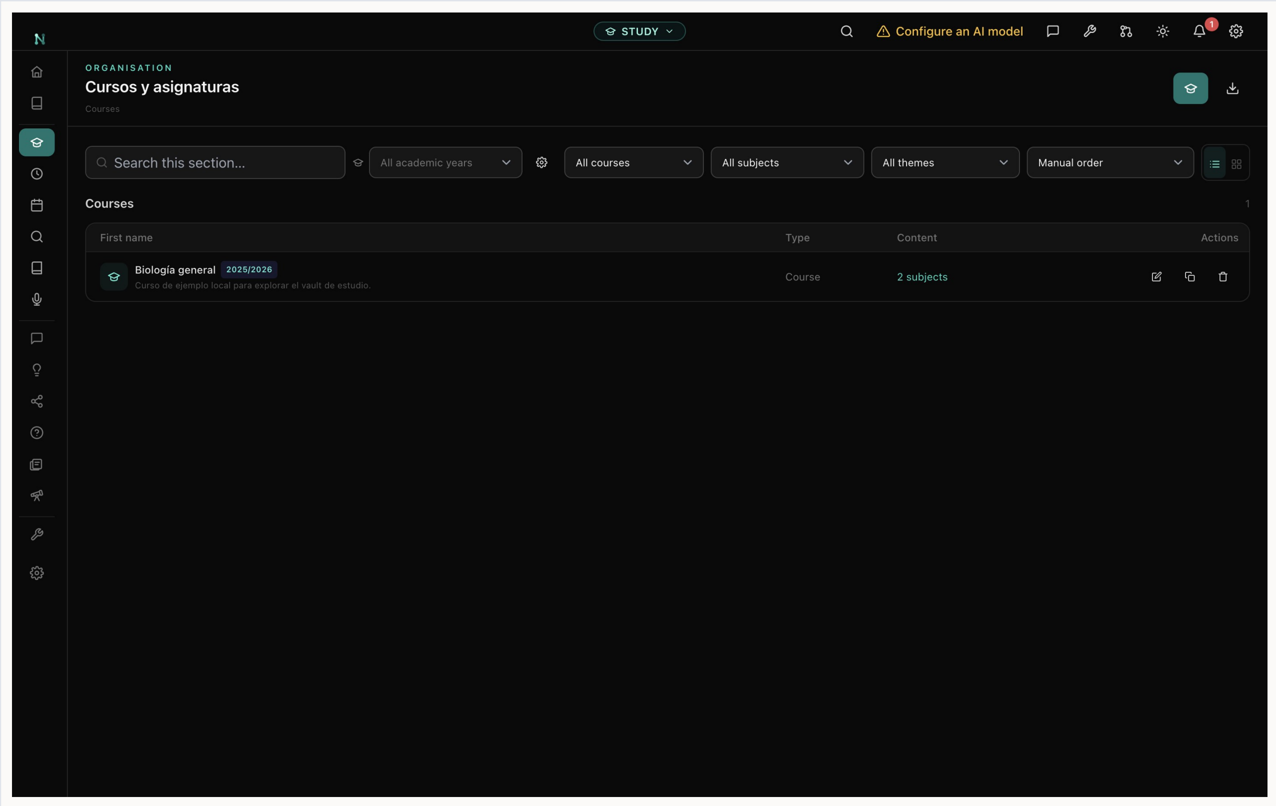
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Courses, subjects, folders and topics

Build a hierarchy that keeps each subject’s materials and AI context separate.

The hierarchy is course to subject to folder to topic to note. Subject colours and icons are reused in schedules, search and learning views.

1. Create the course or degree and add its subjects.
2. Assign a colour and icon, then create only the folders and topics you will use.
3. Move or create notes and materials at the most specific useful level.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Avoid deep empty hierarchies; structure should reduce friction, not add administration.



Courses, subjects, folders and topics in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

3 Schedule

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Schedule

Lay subjects across days and time blocks.

Schedule represents the recurring shape of the week and reuses subject identity. Calendar holds dated events and reminders.

1. Choose the active course and week pattern.
2. Add subject blocks to the correct day and morning or afternoon slot.
3. Review collisions and use Calendar for individual deadlines or exceptions.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Leave unscheduled recovery time instead of filling every block.

ORGANISATION

4 Calendar and reminders

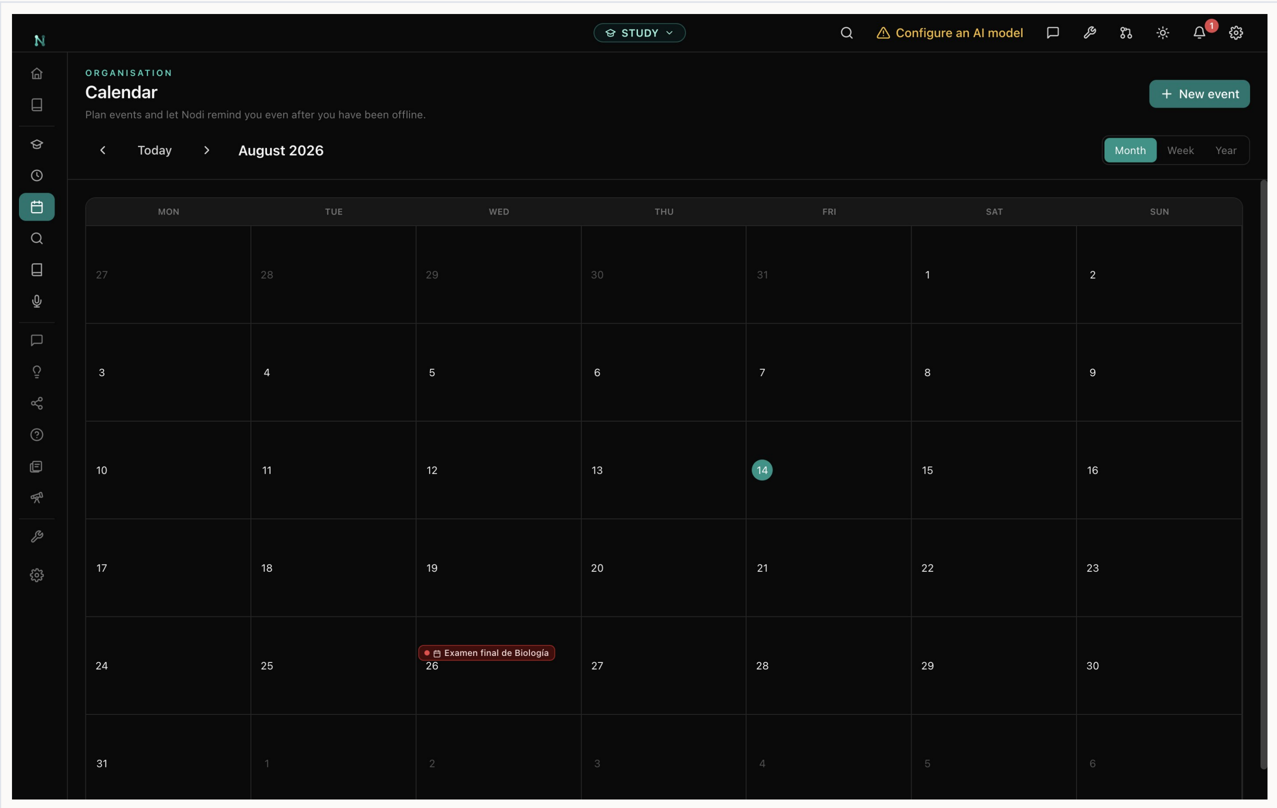
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Calendar and reminders

Plan classes, deadlines, study sessions and exams with local reminders.

Events can carry a type, icon, link and reminder. Optional calendar export or connection should be reviewed before sharing details outside Nodus.

1. Create an event with a clear title, type, date and time.
2. Link it to a subject, material or note and choose a reminder.
3. Use month or agenda views to rebalance crowded periods.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Schedule the preparation sessions, not only the final deadline.



Calendar and reminders in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

5 Workspace search

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Workspace search

Search notes, materials, transcripts, questions and exams in one local index.

Keyword and semantic retrieval return exact pages or timestamps where available.

1. Enter an exact phrase or concept.
2. Filter by subject or content type.
3. Open the page, note or transcript timestamp that supports the result.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Search your own misconceptions and questions, not only official terminology.

ORGANISATION

6 Materials and focused reading

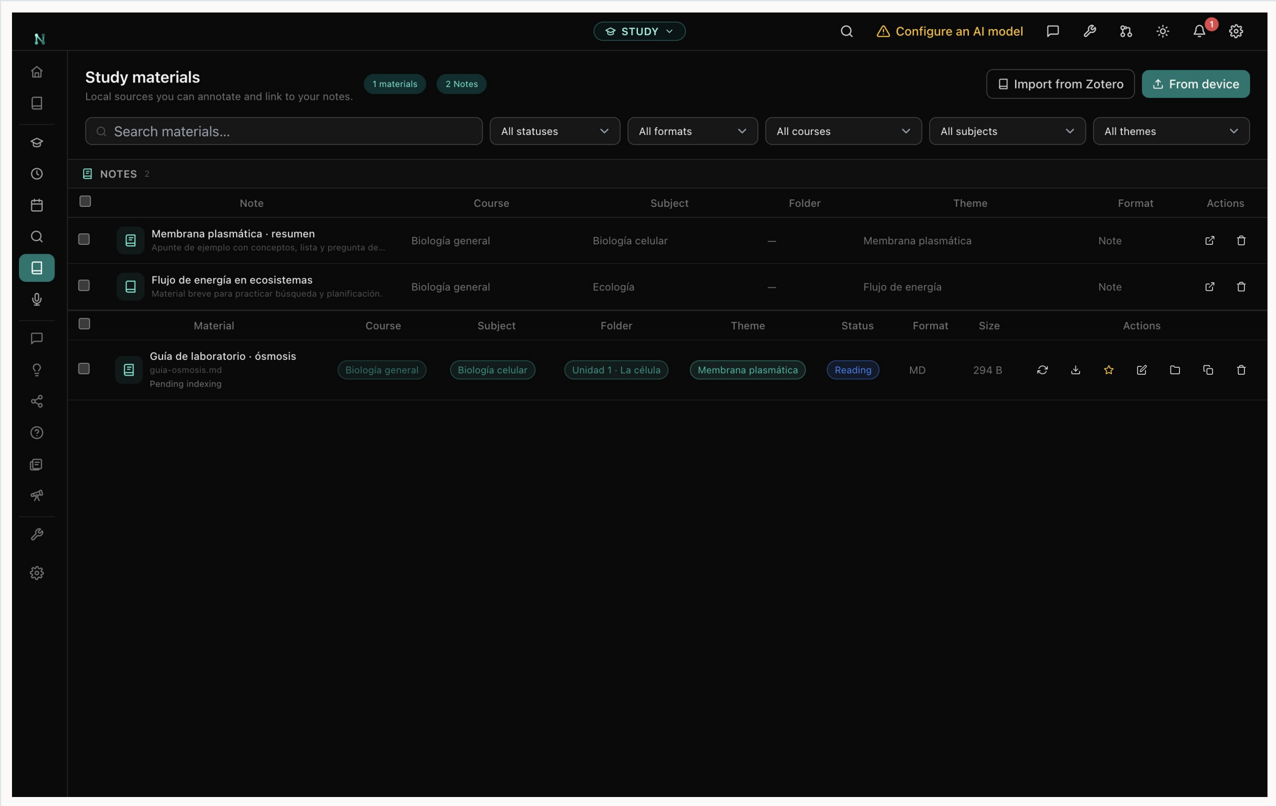
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Materials and focused reading

Import PDFs, documents, slides, EPUBs and audio into the course hierarchy.

Nodus extracts searchable text while preserving the original. Annotations and links connect materials to notes and learning objects.

1. Import a file and assign its subject, folder and topic.
2. Wait for extraction, then open the clean copy or preserved original.
3. Highlight and annotate key passages; create a linked note for synthesis.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Prefer active notes and questions over highlighting entire pages.



Materials and focused reading in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

7 Recordings and local transcripts

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Recordings and local transcripts

Record or import audio, transcribe with local Whisper and jump to exact timestamps.

Recordings can be organised by subject and linked to notes. Local transcription avoids sending classroom audio to a provider.

1. Start a recording with permission or import an existing audio file.
2. Choose local transcription and review the resulting speaker or text segments.
3. Click a transcript line to replay the exact moment and link important segments to a note.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Follow institutional consent rules before recording any class or person.

GUIDED LEARNING

8 Study chat

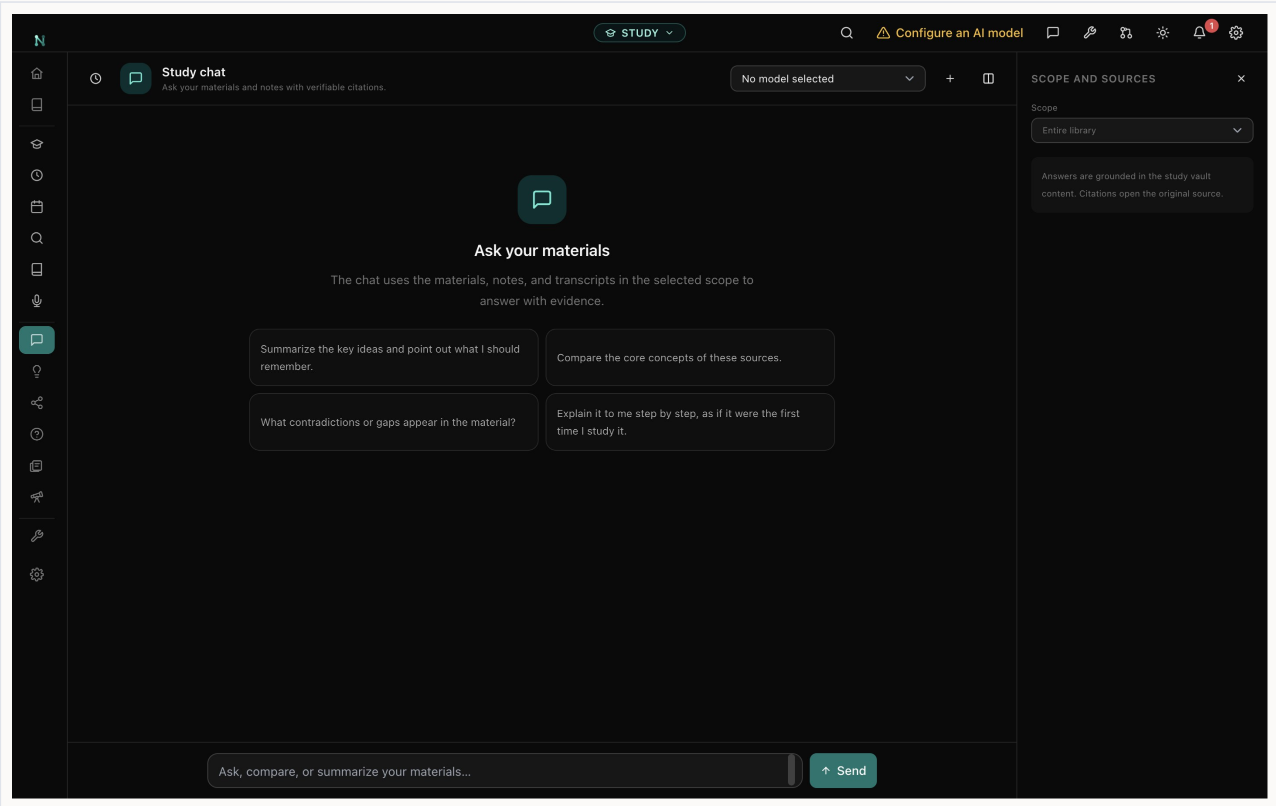
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Study chat

Ask questions grounded in one subject's materials and citations.

Subject isolation prevents unrelated course content from leaking into the answer. Citations lead back to the relevant note, page or transcript.

1. Select the correct subject and check the included sources.
2. Ask for an explanation, comparison or quiz at an appropriate level.
3. Open the cited evidence and correct any unsupported statement.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Ask the tutor to question you before explaining when practising recall.



Study chat in the Nodus desktop application

GUIDED LEARNING

9 Study ideas

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Study ideas

Review concepts extracted from your own notes and materials with verbatim evidence.

Ideas capture definitions, mechanisms and relationships while retaining the subject and source context.

1. Filter ideas by subject or topic.
2. Open one and read its evidence and related ideas.
3. Correct or merge duplicate concepts before using them for questions.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> A concise concept with one clear relation is easier to learn than a paragraph label.

GUIDED LEARNING

10 Study graph

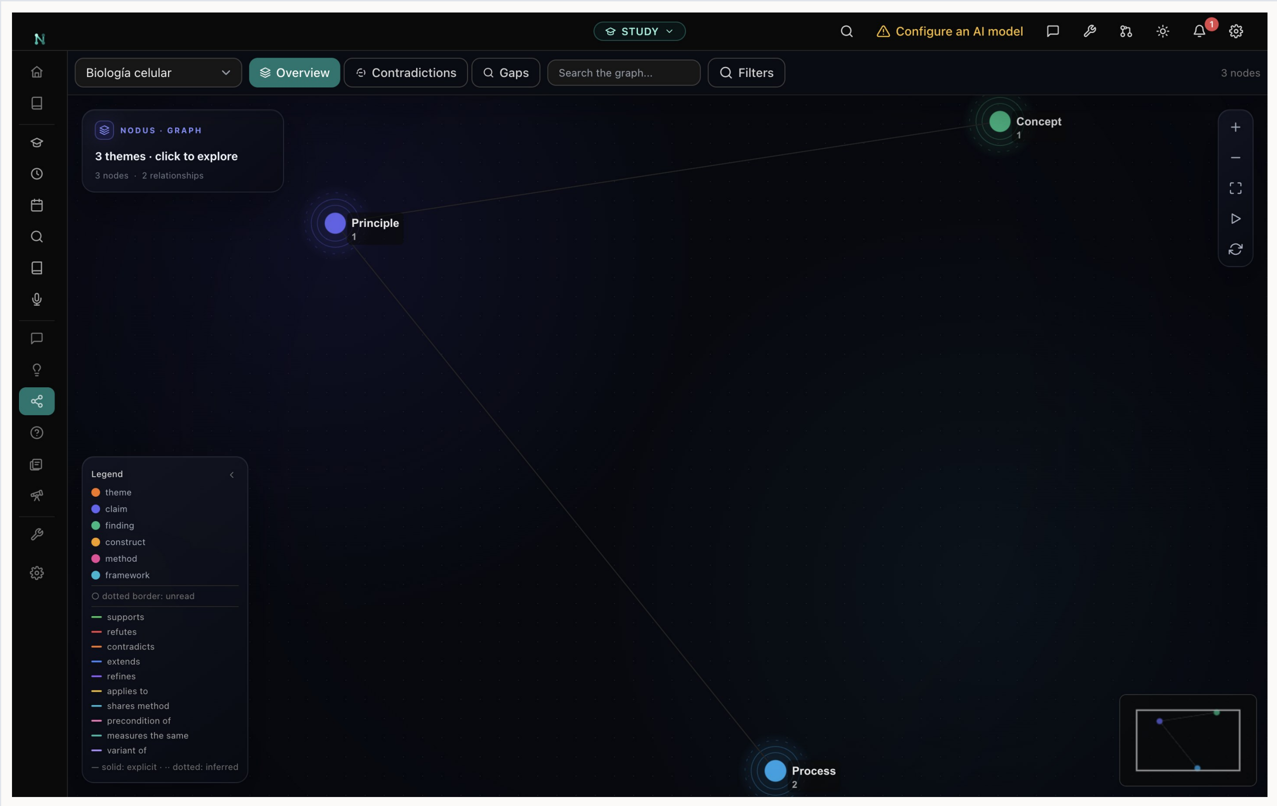
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Study graph

Explore concepts and typed connections as a subject map.

The graph shows supports, contrasts, causes and applications. It is useful for diagnosing isolated concepts and building explanations.

1. Choose one subject and an overview or topic focus.
2. Select a node and explain its outgoing relations in your own words.
3. Open evidence for uncertain edges and repair the underlying idea if needed.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Redraw a small part from memory after exploring it.



Study graph in the Nodus desktop application

ASSESSMENT

11 Question bank, tests and exams

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Question bank, tests and exams

Build approved questions from specific source excerpts.

Questions can be organised by subject, topic, type and difficulty. Generated items remain drafts until reviewed and retain the evidence that justifies the answer.

1. Create manually or generate from selected material.
2. Review wording, answer, distractors, explanation and source excerpt.
3. Approve the item, then assemble it into a practice test or exam.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Reject ambiguous questions even if the expected answer is technically present.

ASSESSMENT

12 Flashcards and spaced review

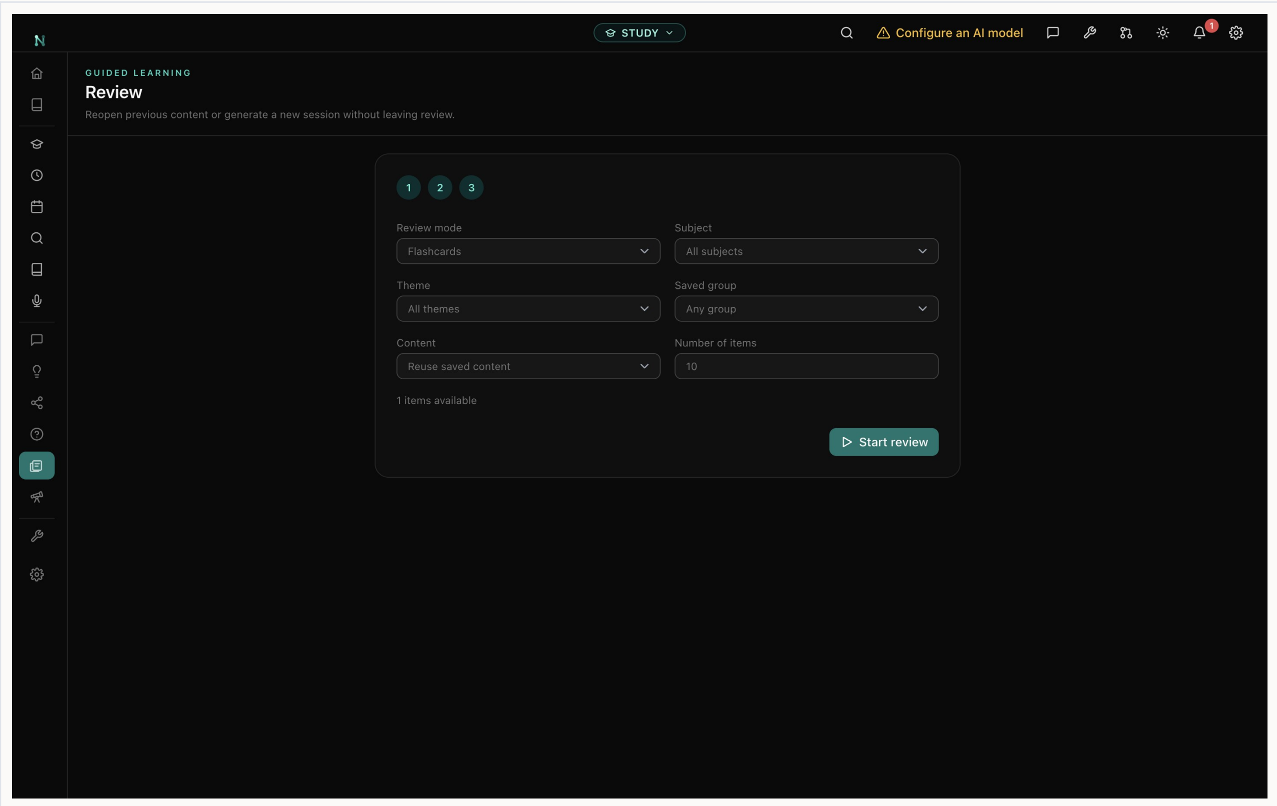
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Flashcards and spaced review

Run focused review sessions and rate recall honestly.

Review can reuse approved content or generate a bounded session. Ratings influence when material returns.

1. Choose subject, scope, session type and length.
2. Answer before revealing the back or explanation.
3. Rate recall based on retrieval quality, not familiarity after seeing the answer.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Short daily sessions outperform occasional marathon reviews.



Flashcards and spaced review in the Nodus desktop application

GUIDED LEARNING

13 Study Research

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Study Research

Create an extended study brief grounded in selected course content.

A study brief organises explanations and citations around a learning question rather than searching the open web by default.

1 Ask a clear question and choose the subject or source scope.
2 Start the report and wait for the queued task to complete.
3 Read actively, open citations and turn key sections into your own questions.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Use a brief as a map back into the material, not as a replacement for it.

WRITE

14 Notes

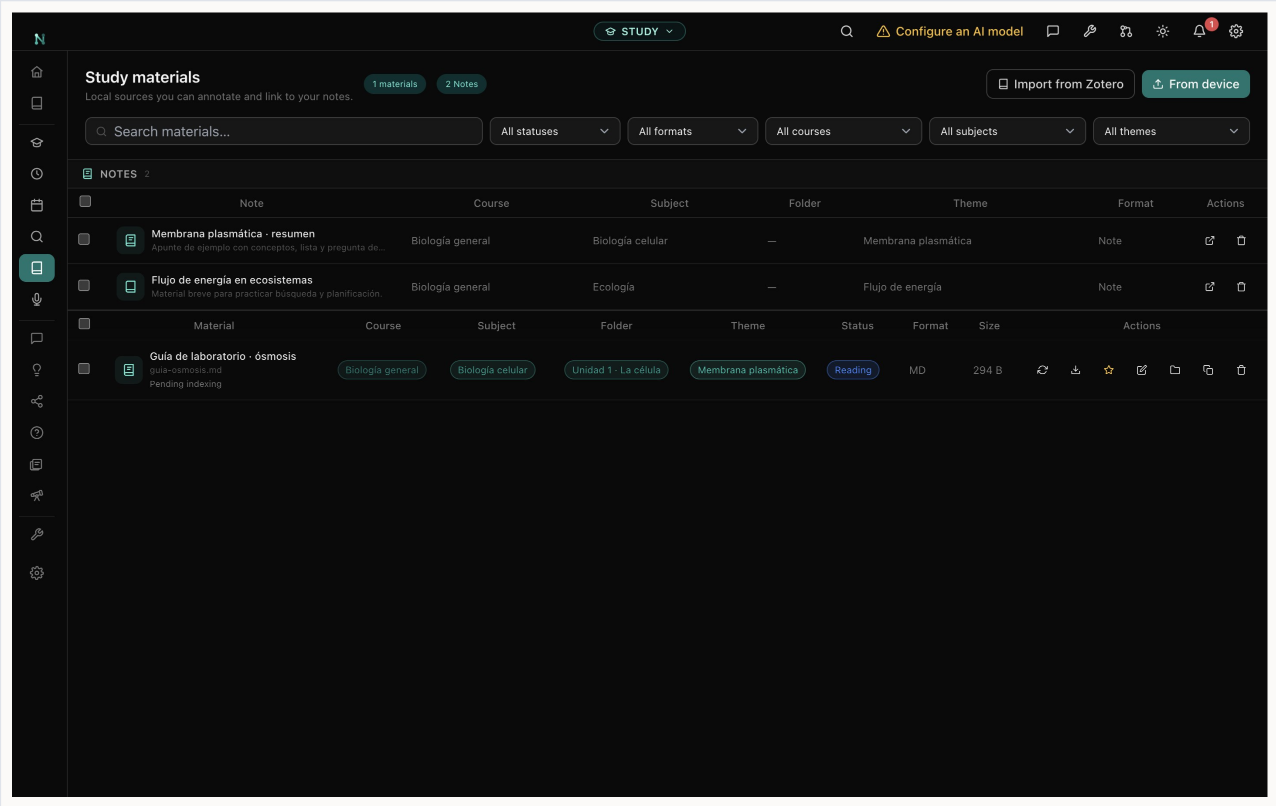
WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Notes

Write free-form notes alongside structured course content.

Notes can link to subjects, topics, materials and ideas. They support scratch work, summaries and reflection without losing context.

1 Create a note under the relevant subject or topic.
2 Use headings and links to separate source notes from your interpretation.
3 Review and convert important statements into questions or ideas.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Write a short retrieval summary before reopening the source.



Notes in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURE

15 Study settings

WHERE TO FIND IT Study vault > Study settings

Control tutor models, local transcription, reminders, privacy and backups.

Study settings make the boundary between local learning tools and optional providers explicit.

1. Choose the model for tutoring and generation, or configure a local endpoint.
2. Enable local Whisper and review microphone permissions.
3. Check reminder behaviour, AI policy and automatic backups.

> **IN PRACTICE**
>
> Do not upload copyrighted or sensitive course material to a provider without permission.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the desktop workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.